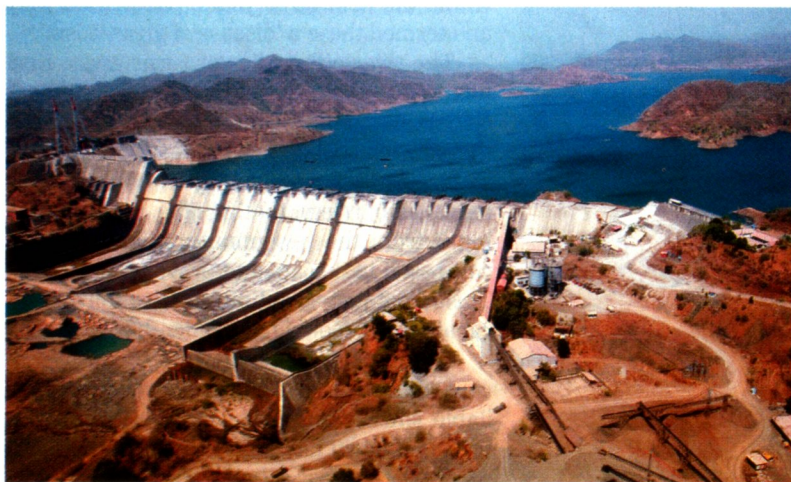


Limited Effect

INDIA HAS 4,600 LARGE DAMS BUILT ACROSS THE COUNTRY. BUT NOT MORE THAN 6 TO 15 PER CENT OF AGRICULTURAL LAND IN EACH STATE IS IRRIGATED BY ANY OF THESE PROJECTS.

**Damning projects:
The Sardar Sarovar
Dam Yojana at Kevadia
Colony in Gujarat**



SHAILESH RAVAL

main mere claims, as the benefits have invariably gone to the powerful demands and lobbies of urban and industrial elites, resulting in grossly iniquitous distribution.

Even with a National Rehabilitation Policy since 2003, river valley projects are not meeting the goal of minimising displacement. This policy, along with rehabilitation acts or notifications in Tribunal awards for river valleys (Narmada and Krishna), means millions of farmers, labourers and fish workers, Dalits and Adivasis included, are uprooted but rarely rehabilitated. The people's struggle in Narmada has brought in land to 11,000 families in Sardar Sarovar, yet thousands of others are still being cheated through non-compliance and massive corruption. The authorities go scot-free, as usual.

Environmental measures include saving the river through allocation of and releases for the downstream flows, which is invariably ignored as in the Sardar Sarovar or dams in Alaknanda, Bhagirathi and Ganga, till grossly irreparable damage is done to the population, which is not even declared as affected. Catchments are not treated, so as to minimise

silt and, hence, the estimates of life span and related benefits prove to be false. Can artificial measures infested with corruption ever compensate natural forests? The limited 'compensatory afforestation' undertaken is resulting in woefully low survival rates, of anywhere between 5 and 20 per cent against the norm of 40 to 75 per cent minimal survival rate, which is 'expensive' paperwork.

The worst is the fraud created in the name of 'cost-benefit analysis'. The exercise undertaken to obtain clearance from the Planning

Commission is invariably based on underestimation of costs and overestimation of benefits. Costs shooting up to five to 10 times the original estimates have become a normal phenomenon. Reviews by sanctioning authorities, including the Planning Commission, are not attempted, even when the comptroller and auditor general's reports expose the benefit-cost ratio going topsy-turvy. The real costs, human and environmental, are never counted, but the huge financial drain itself makes these projects an unviable option. At the national level, not less than Rs 1 to 2 lakh crore is required to complete the dams that have been taken up since the First Five Year Plan, while new tenders are opened up with votes and notes in mind.

What our rivers require are ecologically sustainable ways of harnessing resources in every basin. This includes not just water, but also land and green cover. It has to begin with every stream and rivulet, if not every drop of water that can be stored, keeping some flow intact. Check dams, tanks, ground water recharging, massive afforestation are the solutions, which are non-destructive, non-displacing and decentralised. These solutions generate employment too. A huge potential plan with these works is what can save every river and existing dams from getting converted into silt pans. The drought-affected regions must demand the right to the resources within their command and inputs to trap water in catchments of small to large water bodies, and not transfers through river inter-linking or centralised storage of water behind giant dams. But is the Indian state ready for investment, financial and political, in such a 'macro through micro' approach?

What is true of rivers is also true of our coastal regions. Conserving the mangrove forests and the low and high tide limits for intrusive activities is what is forgotten. The market forces that have an eye on the coastal beauty don't count the natural glory or the priorities of the living generations but only the projects and profits to come. The (un)real estate development, port development and tourism plans these activities mobilise are pushing the Coastal Regulation Zone Policy into the dark and bringing in Coastal Management Zones and Plans, promoting investment as well as ushering investors into hotels, resorts and SEZs. Traditional fishing communities with customary fishing rights, however, are not granted privileges and their life support systems are taken away. This in-